

How important is authenticity for a podcaster?

Soha: It's very important, because these are long conversations. The more time you spend with someone, it's hard to pretend. And the audience is very astute, especially on YouTube. They can smell fake from a mile away. They can smell sponsored from a mile away. So it's better to own it. Everyone wants to make money, and there's nothing wrong with that, but don't pretend that you are not making money. I don't want to have to bleep out the word Bioderma, because I use Bioderma sunscreen and we've done an episode on sunscreen that we've partnered with Bioderma. But I've also partnered with Traya, which I've not used. You should know that this is sponsored. With AI looming over us, authenticity is the key word.

What were you consciously trying for the show not to be?

Soha: I didn't want it to be personality based. I wanted it to be issue based. So if I have Kareena Kapoor, I don't want to talk about Kareena Kapoor. I want to talk about her as a parent and her parenting journey. If I have Shamita Shetty, I want to talk only about endometriosis and a few other things. You have someone popular talking about something, but are they qualified to speak on it? And then you have an expert who is qualified to speak on it, but who's listening to that expert? So get the best of both on one platform, which can be tough, because you need to engage them both and show both of them equal respect.

How much work happens before you sit down with a guest?

Soha: I'm a bit of an over-preparer. I like to do a lot of research and I go through multiple drafts, and we're a very skeletal team, because this has been a pretty bootstrapped initiative. I then put together some questions, and I share them with our guests, because I like them to think about the answer. So it's

not about catching someone off guard. I'm not waiting for them to disclose something. I want them to actually think about what they say and not regret it. Which is tough, because we've committed to doing an episode a week.

Is there something you'd like the platforms to do more of?

Soha: I can only say, as someone who's on YouTube, that I feel there's definitely an algorithm at play and it's very hard to break that algorithm. But the challenge is to not fall into that entirely,

Podcasting is more about bringing out someone else's truth, I feel, and really listening and being able to take out from them what you thought they would be able to contribute to this conversation, and making them comfortable to get there. So in many ways, I feel like I'm the director who's working with someone wanting to get something out of them.

and that's a line that I'm trying to find my own balance with. Everybody will say, it'd be nice to have someone who's real, insinuating that you can't be from Bollywood and be real. But when we have real people who are not famous, I find that that gets less traction, and I'm trying to build a base. I've held back and not put the clickbaity headline, because I'm okay to slowly build. And the statistics that excite me are how long people view the podcast for. Because then you understand that someone's not coming just to see your face or to see the headline or what is scandalous, but they're actually investing in the subject.

Advice for anyone entering the medium today?

Soha: When I started podcasting, a lot of people told me that this is such a crowded space. And my response to them was, just because a place is crowded doesn't mean that it's covering everything. I feel that there's a gap amongst all the noise, which is in wellness for women and health issues. People have very little time, so they go to one, two places for what they want, that they trust. So I would like to be that trusted space for women's health and wellness in India. I would say, know who you are speaking to. Somebody asked me, when you make your content, imagine who you're talking to. And just because somebody tells you a lot of people are doing this, I don't think that should put you off. You can make your niche. You can carve your space.

What are the values a podcaster should not compromise on?

Soha: Firstly, is this podcast going to be your bread and butter? Everybody knows, from YouTube you get a certain amount of money from views, but the people who are really minting money are doing collaborations with brands. And that's where a lot of the money comes from. Are you able to do that in a way that you feel is authentic? Because in the long run, the audience will sniff fake. For me, it's important to have credibility first and to be in the long game. I put my own money into it and recorded 30 episodes without associating with anyone, and created conversation without any strings attached first, and then put that out there. And now we are partnering again with brands. I would say put a disclaimer that this is sponsored. I'm making money off this, but I'm benefiting from this. The line between your real life and what you put out, even if there's a difference, it shouldn't be so much of a difference that you are being fake. 